

Deck Maintenance Checklist

Your Complete Guide to Keeping Your Deck Beautiful & Safe

From Hero Handyman Pro

Serving St. Louis & Metro East

Why Regular Deck Maintenance Matters

A well-maintained deck can last 20+ years, while a neglected deck may need replacement in as little as 10 years. Regular maintenance protects your investment, ensures safety, and keeps your outdoor space looking beautiful. This comprehensive checklist will help you maintain your deck throughout the year.

Spring Maintenance (March - May)

Inspection

- ☐ **Check for winter damage** - Look for cracks, splits, or warping in deck boards
- ☐ **Inspect railings** - Test for loose posts, balusters, or handrails
- ☐ **Examine stairs** - Check treads, risers, and stringers for damage
- ☐ **Look for rot** - Use a screwdriver to probe suspicious areas (soft wood indicates rot)
- ☐ **Check fasteners** - Look for popped nails, loose screws, or rusted hardware
- ☐ **Inspect ledger board** - Ensure it's securely attached to the house
- ☐ **Check flashing** - Verify flashing is intact where deck meets the house
- ☐ **Examine joists and beams** - Look underneath for signs of damage or sagging

Cleaning

- ☐ **Remove debris** - Clear leaves, dirt, and organic matter from deck surface
- ☐ **Clean between boards** - Use a putty knife to remove debris from gaps
- ☐ **Wash the deck** - Use deck cleaner or mild soap and water with a stiff brush
- ☐ **Rinse thoroughly** - Remove all cleaning solution to prevent residue
- ☐ **Clean railings and stairs** - Don't forget vertical surfaces
- ☐ **Allow to dry completely** - Wait 48 hours before sealing or staining

Repairs

- ☐ **Replace damaged boards** - Remove and replace any cracked or rotted boards
- ☐ **Tighten loose fasteners** - Secure any loose screws or nails
- ☐ **Sand rough spots** - Smooth any splintered or rough areas
- ☐ **Fill gaps and cracks** - Use wood filler for small cracks
- ☐ **Repair or replace damaged railings** - Ensure all railings are secure

Protection

- ☐ **Apply deck cleaner/brightener** - Restore wood's natural color
 - ☐ **Seal or stain** - Apply water-repellent sealer or stain (every 2-3 years)
 - ☐ **Allow proper drying time** - Follow manufacturer's instructions for curing
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Summer Maintenance (June - August)

Regular Care

- ☐ **Sweep weekly** - Remove dirt, leaves, and debris
- ☐ **Move furniture periodically** - Prevent uneven fading and allow air circulation
- ☐ **Clean spills immediately** - Prevent staining from food, drinks, or grease

- ☐ **Trim vegetation** - Keep plants from touching deck to prevent moisture damage
- ☐ **Check for mold/mildew** - Clean any growth with appropriate cleaner
- ☐ **Inspect after storms** - Look for new damage after severe weather

Safety Checks

- ☐ **Test railings monthly** - Ensure they're still secure
 - ☐ **Check for splinters** - Sand any new rough spots immediately
 - ☐ **Verify stair stability** - Test handrails and treads
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Fall Maintenance (September - November)

Preparation for Winter

- ☐ **Deep clean** - Remove all summer grime and prepare for winter
- ☐ **Clear gutters above deck** - Prevent water overflow onto deck
- ☐ **Trim overhanging branches** - Reduce leaf accumulation and prevent damage
- ☐ **Remove or cover furniture** - Protect outdoor furniture from winter weather
- ☐ **Store planters** - Remove heavy planters that can trap moisture
- ☐ **Check drainage** - Ensure water flows away from deck properly
- ☐ **Apply final coat of sealer** - If needed, apply before first freeze

Final Inspection

- ☐ **Check all fasteners** - Tighten any that have loosened during summer
 - ☐ **Inspect for pest damage** - Look for signs of termites or carpenter ants
 - ☐ **Verify structural integrity** - Ensure posts and beams are solid
 - ☐ **Document condition** - Take photos to compare next spring
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Winter Maintenance (December - February)

Cold Weather Care

- ☐ **Remove snow promptly** - Use plastic shovel to avoid damaging deck surface
- ☐ **Avoid ice melt chemicals** - Use sand for traction instead of salt
- ☐ **Check for ice dams** - Ensure proper drainage to prevent ice buildup
- ☐ **Inspect after heavy snow** - Look for sagging or structural stress
- ☐ **Keep deck clear** - Don't allow snow to accumulate for extended periods

Planning

- ☐ **Plan spring repairs** - Make a list of needed repairs for spring
 - ☐ **Order materials** - Purchase replacement boards or supplies during off-season sales
 - ☐ **Schedule professional inspection** - Book early for spring maintenance
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Monthly Quick Checks (Year-Round)

- ☐ **Sweep deck surface** - Remove debris
 - ☐ **Check railings** - Quick shake test for stability
 - ☐ **Look for new damage** - Spot issues early
 - ☐ **Clean spills immediately** - Prevent staining
 - ☐ **Remove standing water** - Prevent rot and mildew
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When to Call a Professional

Contact Hero Handyman Pro if you notice:

- **Structural issues** - Sagging, bouncing, or visible rot in support beams
- **Extensive rot** - Multiple boards or joists showing signs of decay

- **Loose ledger board** - Where deck attaches to house
 - **Widespread cracking** - Multiple boards with significant cracks
 - **Railing instability** - Railings that move more than slightly
 - **Stair problems** - Loose, sagging, or damaged stairs
 - **Code compliance concerns** - Outdated construction that may not meet current codes
 - **Major repairs needed** - Any repair beyond your skill level
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Deck Maintenance Schedule Summary

Season	Priority Tasks	Frequency
Spring	Deep clean, inspect, repair, seal/stain	Annual
Summer	Sweep, clean spills, safety checks	Weekly/Monthly
Fall	Final clean, winterize, final inspection	Annual
Winter	Snow removal, monitor for damage	As needed
Year-Round	Quick checks, immediate spill cleanup	Monthly

Pro Tips for Long-Lasting Decks

1. **Seal regularly** - Every 2-3 years for wood decks, or when water no longer beads on surface
2. **Address issues immediately** - Small problems become big (expensive) problems if ignored
3. **Improve drainage** - Ensure water flows away from deck and house
4. **Ventilate underneath** - Good airflow prevents moisture buildup and rot
5. **Use proper fasteners** - Stainless steel or coated screws resist rust
6. **Avoid pressure washing** - Can damage wood fibers; use gentle cleaning instead
7. **Keep it dry** - Remove standing water and ensure proper spacing between boards

8. **Protect from sun** - UV rays damage wood; use UV-protective sealers

Need Help with Deck Maintenance or Repairs?

Hero Handyman Pro provides comprehensive deck maintenance and repair services throughout St. Louis & Metro East.

- ✓ Free deck inspections
- ✓ Professional repairs and restoration
- ✓ Deck cleaning and sealing
- ✓ Same-day/next-day service available
- ✓ 30+ years of experience
- ✓ Licensed & insured

Call us today: 800-741-6056

Visit: hero handyman pro.com

This checklist is provided as a general guide. Always follow manufacturer recommendations for your specific decking material. For composite or PVC decks, consult manufacturer guidelines as maintenance requirements differ from wood decks.

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